

BILINGUAL EDITION

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# Buying Your First Home in Québec

*The complete first-time buyer's guide – from idea to keys*

ÉDITION 2026

## AVIS IMPORTANT

This book is **educational** content. It is not personalized legal, tax, financial or mortgage advice. Amounts and rules cited are indicative for the **2026 edition** and must be validated at the time of your project. Book a free consultation with Émilie Cauvier.

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01

BILINGUAL EDITION

## **Are you ready to buy?**

*Honestly assess your ability to buy before falling in love with a property.*

# Are you ready to buy?

Honestly assess your ability to buy before falling in love with a property.

**A** solid purchase rests on three pillars: the down payment (the cash you put in), your borrowing capacity (how much a lender will approve based on income, debts and credit), and your ability to carry the ongoing costs of ownership without strain.

## The true cost of owning

- Municipal and school taxes (often several hundred dollars a month).
- Home insurance.
- Condo fees if applicable (operating fund + contingency fund).
- Energy (Hydro-Québec, heating).
- Maintenance reserve: budget roughly 1% of the property value per year.

Lenders review two ratios (GDS and TDS) and your credit score. Paying down credit-card debt before buying often boosts your borrowing capacity more than saving a bit more cash.

### LE CONSEIL D'ÉMILIE

Never shop for a property before running your numbers. Starting with your budget is what makes the search enjoyable instead of stressful.

## MES NOTES

## Mes notes — Are you ready to buy?

### QUESTIONS POUR LANCER MA RÉFLEXION :

- *What is my household's gross annual income?*
- *Which monthly debts could I reduce before buying?*
- *What is my approximate credit score (check with Equifax or TransUnion)?*

# 02

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## **Funding your down payment**

*Gather your down payment using every available tool.*

# Funding your down payment

Gather your down payment using every available tool.

**M**inimum down payment depends on price (2026 edition, to confirm): 5% up to \$500,000, 10% on the portion from \$500,000 to \$999,999, and 20% at \$1,000,000 and up. Below 20%, mortgage-loan insurance (CMHC, Sagen, Canada Guaranty) applies and is added to your loan.

- FHSA: contributions are tax-deductible AND withdrawals for a first home are tax-free (about \$8,000/year, up to \$40,000 lifetime, to confirm).
- HBP (RRSP Home Buyers' Plan): withdraw up to \$60,000 per person, tax-free upfront, repaid over 15 years (to confirm).
- Family gift: accepted as down payment with a gift letter confirming it is not a loan.
- FHSA and HBP can be combined for a first purchase.

## 💡 LE CONSEIL D'ÉMILIE

Meet a mortgage broker BEFORE withdrawing anything. The order and timing of FHSA vs RRSP withdrawals has a real tax impact.

## MES NOTES

## Mes notes — Funding your down payment

### QUESTIONS POUR LANCER MA RÉFLEXION :

- *What minimum down payment applies to my price range?*
- *What do I hold in RRSP (HBP) and FHSA?*
- *Is a family gift possible, and how much?*

03

BILINGUAL EDITION

# Mortgage pre-approval

*Get a confirmed amount and a rate hold before you shop.*

# Mortgage pre-approval

Get a confirmed amount and a rate hold before you shop.

**P**re-qualification is a quick estimate with no verification. Pre-approval is different: the lender reviews your documents and confirms an amount plus a guaranteed rate for a period (often 90 to 120 days). That is what gives your offers weight.

Lenders qualify you at a rate higher than your actual rate (the stress test) to ensure you could absorb an increase, so your approved amount may be more conservative than expected – that is a protection. A mortgage broker shops several lenders for you, often at no cost.

## LE CONSEIL D'ÉMILIE

With a pre-approval in hand, you stop dreaming and start choosing. In a fast market, it can be the difference between winning a home and watching it go.



# 04

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## **Visiting, inspecting and making an offer**

*See past the décor and make a solid, protected offer.*

# Visiting, inspecting and making an offer

See past the décor and make a solid, protected offer.

**D**uring visits, look at structure, not furniture: cracks, basement moisture, roof age, windows, electrical panel, water heater and furnace age. Ask whether renovations were done with permits.

## Québec-specific checks

- Clay soils (Montréal, Laval, North Shore): movement and cracks.
- Pyrite, aging French drain, buried oil tank, vermiculite (possible asbestos).
- Always make your offer conditional on a professional inspection.

A promise to purchase is binding once accepted. Protective conditions (inspection, financing, review of documents) are legitimate exit doors. Price your offer from a comparative market analysis, not emotion, and set a firm maximum in advance.

### LE CONSEIL D'ÉMILIE

A winning offer is not always the highest: it is often the cleanest – reasonable conditions, dates that suit the seller, solid financing. It reassures the seller as much as the price.

## MES NOTES

## Mes notes — Visiting, inspecting and making an offer

### QUESTIONS POUR LANCER MA RÉFLEXION :

- *What should the inspector check first?*
- *What is my absolute maximum price, decided in advance?*

# 05

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## **Closing and the Welcome Tax**

*Understand the final stretch and avoid cost surprises.*

# Closing and the Welcome Tax

Understand the final stretch and avoid cost surprises.

**I**n Québec, the deed of sale is signed before a notary, who verifies title, prepares the deeds, handles funds and registers the sale. Budget closing costs: notary fees, inspection, adjustments, possibly an updated certificate of location, and home insurance active on possession day.

## The Welcome Tax (transfer duties)

A municipal tax billed a few weeks or months after purchase, calculated in brackets on the greater of the price paid or the adjusted municipal assessment. Montréal adds higher brackets on expensive properties. Always get an estimate BEFORE buying and set the money aside.

### LE CONSEIL D'ÉMILIE

Set the Welcome Tax money aside on closing day, in a separate account. It usually arrives right after you've spent on moving – planning for it avoids the one bad memory of an otherwise great purchase.

## MES NOTES

## Mes notes — Closing and the Welcome Tax

### QUESTIONS POUR LANCER MA RÉFLEXION :

- *What is my estimated Welcome Tax, and is it set aside?*
- *What total closing-cost envelope should I plan for?*

# 06

PASSER À L'ACTION

## **Plan d'action**

# Plan d'action

Vos prochains pas, concrètement.

## Cette semaine

- 0 Calculate my real budget and check my credit score.
- 0 Gather my financial documents.

## D'ici 30 jours

- 0 Meet a mortgage broker and get a pre-approval.
- 0 Optimize FHSA and HBP with an advisor.
- 0 Define my criteria and two target areas.

## Ensuite

- 0 Book a free consultation with Émilie to launch the search with a clear plan.

07

POUR ALLER PLUS LOIN

## Ressources & lexique

# Ressources & lexique

Les repères essentiels à garder sous la main.

- GDS / TDS: debt ratios used by lenders.
- FHSA: first-home savings account, deductible contributions and tax-free withdrawal.
- HBP: RRSP Home Buyers' Plan, up to \$60,000/person, repaid over 15 years.
- Welcome Tax: municipal transfer duties, billed after purchase.
- Certificate of location: surveyor's document describing the property.
- OACIQ: body regulating real estate brokerage and protecting the public in Québec.

## ÉVALUATION

# Testez vos acquis

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Dix questions pour ancrer l'essentiel de ce guide. Répondez, puis vérifiez avec le corrigé commenté.

**1. The minimum down payment for a \$450,000 home is generally:**

- A) 20%
- B) 10%
- C) 5%
- D) 0%

**2. The FHSA is special because:**

- A) Contributions are deductible AND withdrawals for a first home are tax-free
- B) It has no limit
- C) It replaces pre-approval
- D) It is for investors only

**3. A pre-approval:**

- A) Is a rough estimate with no verification
- B) Confirms an amount and holds a rate for a period
- C) Forces you to buy within a week
- D) Is issued by the notary

**4. The stress test qualifies you at:**

- A) Your actual rate
- B) A rate higher than your actual rate
- C) 0%
- D) The seller's rate

**5. In Québec, the deed of sale is signed before:**

- A) A mortgage broker
- B) An inspector
- C) A notary
- D) A surveyor

**6. The Welcome Tax is:**

- A) Paid monthly with the mortgage
- B) Billed by the municipality after purchase, in brackets
- C) Included in notary fees
- D) Only in Montréal

**7. An inspection should be:**

- A) Optional and after closing
- B) A condition of the offer, by a professional
- C) Done by the seller
- D) Replaced by listing photos

**8. A clay-soil area can cause:**

- A) Nothing
- B) Foundation movement and cracks
- C) Better insulation
- D) Energy savings

**CORRIGÉ COMMENTÉ**

1. **C** – 5% up to \$500,000 (chapter 2).
2. **A** – Best of both worlds (chapter 2).
3. **B** – Confirmed amount + rate hold (chapter 3).
4. **B** – A safety margin (chapter 3).
5. **C** – The notary verifies title and registers the sale (chapter 5).
6. **B** – A separate municipal bill after closing (chapter 5).
7. **B** – Your key protection (chapter 4).
8. **B** – Clay swells and shrinks (chapter 4).

## So what now? Let's talk about YOUR project.

You have the roadmap. The next step is to apply it to **your** situation. Book a free consultation, with no obligation.

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### DANS LA MÊME COLLECTION

- Selling Your Home in Greater Montréal
- Devenir propriétaire au Québec
- La taxe de bienvenue expliquée
- La préapprobation hypothécaire décodée